

First Read

ZTO Express

Winning on quality over quantity

Q1 slightly missed on lower subsidies; core profit tracked revenue

ZTO's Q126 results slightly missed expectations. Revenue grew strongly by 22% YoY (vs. consensus estimate of 18%), while adjusted net profit only recorded a 5% YoY increase (vs. expectation of 7%), dragged down by a reduction in government subsidies. Excluding this one-off impact, the YoY growth of the company's operating profit was largely consistent with that of revenue. In addition, the company maintains its full-year parcel volume growth guidance of 10-13%.

Market share gains driven by quality clients

Despite the industry's growth slowdown amid the "anti-involution" backdrop, ZTO's parcel vol achieved a robust 13% YoY growth in Q1, notably outpacing the industry (6%) and expanding its market share by 1.4ppts, thanks to its better customer mix and service quality. Meanwhile, express ASP improved by Rmb11 cents YoY, driven by the growth of KA (Key Accounts) business (contributing an 18-cent lift) and increased parcel weight (a 2-cent lift), which more than offset the drag from volume-based incentives (dragging down ASP by 9 cents). On the cost side, Q1 unit cost increased by Rmb8 cents YoY, which was also mainly due to the expansion of KA vol. However, the core cost per parcel decreased by 6 cents YoY, with transport and sorting cost down 4 cents and 2 cents, respectively, demonstrating the results of the company's cost-reduction and efficiency-enhancement initiatives (automation, AI, etc.). Overall, the company's adjusted NP per parcel in Q1 was Rmb25 cents (vs. 26 cents in last Q2).

Policy tailwinds support higher earnings forecast + buyback commitment

According to our channel checks, the industry's "anti-involution" policies are expected to continue. We further raise our assumption for the company's express ASP for the full year 2026, which in turn moves our forecast for its adjusted NP 4% higher. Looking at the second quarter, we expect the company's adjusted NP to achieve YoY growth of c40% on a low base last year. Regarding shareholder returns, ZTO's CFO, Ms. Yan, mentioned during our conference call today that the remaining US\$800 million of the previously issued US\$1.5 billion convertible bonds will largely be used for share buybacks within the year.

Valuation: Maintain Buy

We are optimistic that ZTO will further consolidate and expand its leading advantage against the backdrop of "anti-involution," and we maintain our Buy rating.

Equities

China
Transportation Services

12-month rating **Buy**

12m price target **US\$28.00**

Price (19 May 2026) **US\$23.55**

RIC: ZTO.N BBG: ZTO US

Trading data and key metrics

52-wk range	US\$25.88-16.76
Market cap.	US\$18.8b
Shares o/s	800m (ORD)
Free float	73%
Avg. daily volume ('000)	431
Avg. daily value (m)	US\$10.6
Common s/h equity (12/26E)	Rmb73.7b
P/BV (12/26E)	1.7x
Net debt to EBITDA (12/26E)	NM

EPS (UBS, diluted) (Rmb)

	From	To	% ch	Cons.
12/26E	13.56	14.16	4	13.04
12/27E	14.71	15.36	4	14.68
12/28E	15.57	16.26	4	16.04

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Highlights (Rmbm)	12/23	12/24	12/25	12/26E	12/27E	12/28E	12/29E	12/30E
Revenues	38,419	44,281	49,099	58,704	63,326	66,446	69,722	73,162
EBIT (UBS)	10,263	12,096	10,704	13,539	14,615	15,341	16,104	16,905
Net earnings (UBS)	8,836	10,067	9,395	11,529	12,506	13,235	14,024	14,876
EPS (UBS, diluted) (Rmb)	10.53	12.01	11.45	14.16	15.36	16.26	17.23	18.28
DPS (net) (Rmb)	4.40	5.10	4.88	6.06	6.57	6.95	7.37	7.82
Net (debt) / cash	12,709	12,837	14,727	18,927	24,477	31,286	39,369	48,730
Profitability/valuation	12/23	12/24	12/25	12/26E	12/27E	12/28E	12/29E	12/30E
EBIT (UBS) margin %	26.7	27.3	21.8	23.1	23.1	23.1	23.1	23.1
ROIC (EBIT) %	25.1	26.3	21.8	26.1	26.9	27.6	28.8	30.5
EV/EBITDA (UBS core) x	10.0	7.1	6.9	6.4	5.7	5.0	4.4	3.8
P/E (UBS, diluted) x	17.3	12.5	12.0	11.4	10.4	9.9	9.3	8.8
Equity FCF (UBS) yield %	4.5	4.6	5.4	6.4	8.2	9.5	10.7	12.0
Dividend yield (net) %	2.4	3.3	3.6	3.8	4.1	4.3	4.6	4.9

Source: Company accounts, LSEG Eikon, UBS estimates. Metrics marked as (UBS) have had analyst adjustments applied. Valuations: based on an average share price that year, (E): based on a share price of US\$ 22.61 on 20-May-2026

Forecast returns

Forecast price appreciation	18.9%
Forecast dividend yield	3.8%
Forecast stock return	22.7%
Market return assumption	10.9%
Forecast excess return	11.8%

Company Description

ZTO Express is a leading express delivery company in China. It provides express delivery services via a nationwide network and other value-added logistics services. As of 31 Dec 2019, the company had centralised control and management of 91 sorting hubs, a fleet of over 7,350 line-haul vehicles (6,450 self-owned) and a market share of 19% in China. ZTO Express was listed on the NYSE in 2016.

Valuation Method and Risk Statement

Our price target is based on PE. ZTO's volume growth is highly sensitive to the pace of eCommerce and economic growth. A meaningful deceleration could drive downside to our EPS estimates and stock price. The other major downside risk is from a larger-than-expected decline in average price per parcel and smaller-than-expected cost savings from fleet management and automation. Other sources of error include, but are not limited to, significant changes in logistics strategy by large eCommerce companies, decline in domestic consumption, exchange rate volatility and US regulation changes which could impact ADR performances.

Quantitative Research Review

UBS Global Research publishes a quantitative assessment of its analysts' responses to certain questions about the likelihood of an occurrence of a number of short term factors in a product known as the 'Quantitative Research Review'. The views for this month can be found below. Views contained in this assessment on a particular stock reflect only the views on those short term factors which are a different timeframe to the 12-month timeframe reflected in any equity rating set out in this note. For previous responses please make reference to (i) previous UBS Global Research reports; and (ii) where no applicable research report was published that month, the Quantitative Research Review which can be found at <https://neo.ubs.com/quantitative>, or contact your UBS sales representative for access to the report or the Quantitative Research Team on ubs-quant-answers@ubs.com. A consolidated report which contains all responses is also available and again you should contact your UBS sales representative for details and pricing or the Quantitative Research Team on the email above.

ZTO Express

Question	Response
1. Is the industry structure facing the firm likely to improve or deteriorate over the next six months? Rate on a scale of 1-5 (1 = getting worse, 3 = no change, 5 = getting better, N/A = no view)	3
2. Is the regulatory/government environment facing the firm likely to improve or deteriorate over the next six months? Rate on a scale of 1-5 (1 = getting tougher, 3 = no change, 5 = getting better, N/A = no view)	3
3. Over the last 3-6 months in broad terms have things been improving/no change/getting worse for this stock? Rate on a scale of 1-5 (1 = getting a lot worse, 3 = not much change, 5 = getting a lot better, N/A = no view)	4
4. Relative to the current CONSENSUS EPS forecast, is the next company EPS update likely to lead to: (1 = negative surprise vs consensus, 3 = in-line with consensus, 5 = positive surprise vs consensus expectations, N/A = no view)	3
5. What's driving the difference?	
6. Relative to YOUR current earnings forecast, is there relatively greater risk at the next earnings result of: (1 = downside skew risk to earnings, 3 = equal upside or downside risk to earnings, 5 = upside skew risk to earnings, N/A = no view)	3
7. What's driving the difference?	
8. Is there an upcoming catalyst for the company over the next three months?	No Catalyst
9. Is there an actual or approximate date for the catalyst?	
10. Is the catalyst date an actual or approximate date?	N/A
11. What is the catalyst?	

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12-Month Rating	Definition	Coverage ¹	IB Services ²
Buy	FSR is > 6% above the MRA.	54%	24%
Neutral	FSR is between -6% and 6% of the MRA.	40%	21%
Sell	FSR is > 6% below the MRA.	6%	21%

Source: UBS. Rating allocations are as of 31 March 2026.

1:Percentage of companies under coverage globally within the 12-month rating category.

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Company Name	Reuters	12-month rating	Price	Price date
ZTO Express ^{16,28}	ZTO.N	Buy	US\$22.61	20 May 2026

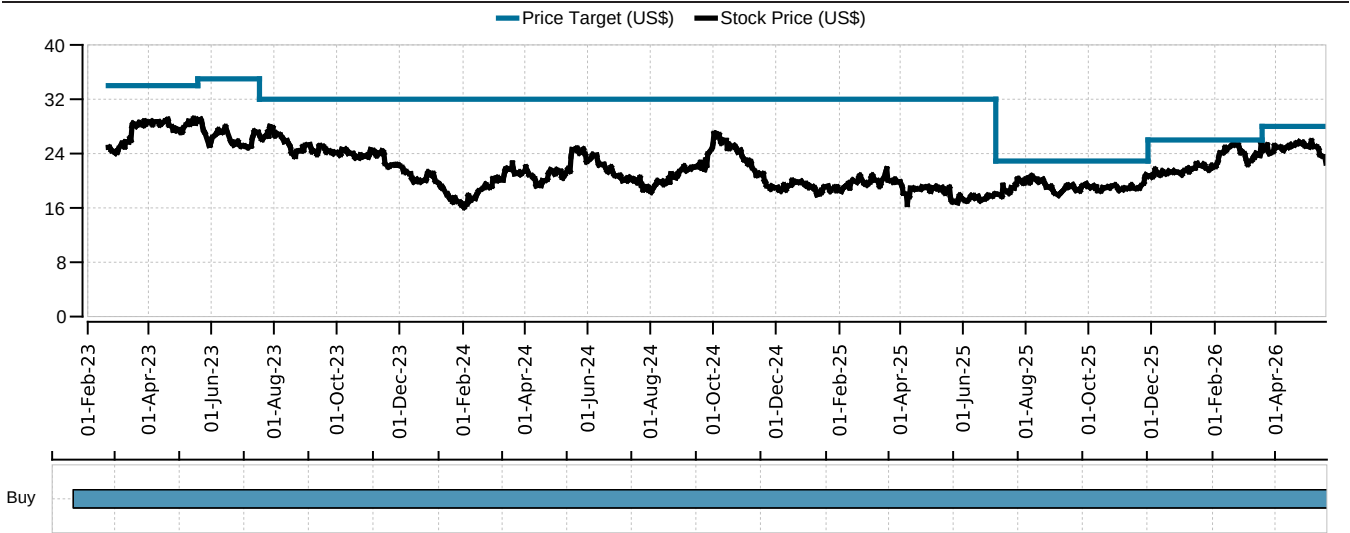
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ZTO Express (US\$)



Date	Stock Price (US\$)	Price Target (US\$)	Rating
2023-02-20	NaN	34.00	Buy
2023-05-18	29.04	35.00	Buy
2023-07-17	27.12	32.00	Buy
2025-07-02	18.04	22.90	Buy
2025-11-27	20.87	26.00	Buy
2026-03-18	25.51	28.00	Buy

Source: UBS Global Research; LSEG Eikon as of 20-May-2026. All prices as of local market close. Ratings as of date shown.

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